

Indian Physiography & Drainage Systems

Himalayan ranges, Peninsular block, Himalayan vs Peninsular rivers — map PYQ core.

Portion focus ~45% · Topic: geo-india

PYQ themes: Physiographic divisions · River systems · Passes & peaks

Why UPSC asks this

Location literacy is non-negotiable; river origin–tributary–sea pairs are classic.

Physiographic divisions

Northern mountains, northern plains, Peninsular plateau, coastal plains, islands. Inside Himalayas: Himadri–Himachal–Shiwalik logic; syntaxial bends; northeast ranges.

Drainage contrasts

Himalayan rivers: perennial, antecedent/longitudinal profiles, high sediment. Peninsular: more rain-fed, older broad valleys, some west-flowing exceptions. Match tributaries carefully (Yamuna, Ghaghara, Son, Chambal, etc.).

Map / list facts

- Khyber, Bolan, Nathu La, Bomdi La — strategic passes (selective)
- Western/Eastern Ghats & Deccan plateau

Must remember

- Indus, Ganga, Brahmaputra Himalayan systems; Godavari–Krishna–Cauvery–Narmada–Tapi Peninsular
- Narmada–Tapi rift valleys west-flowing
- Doab, terai, bhabar vocabulary